community, initially called the Arakan League for Democracy (ALD). Its manifesto was explicitly anti-Rohingya from the start and called for the exclusion of the Rohingyas from the electoral process and the establishment of Rakhine villages in areas with a Rohingya majority.[74] Rohingya activists and politicians note that this party was closely allied to the NLD and joined with the NLD in challenging the validity of those elections which had been won by ethnically Rohingya candidates.[75]

Renamed as the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (RNDP), it contested the 2010 elections and won the majority of seats in the province. The change of name has done nothing to dampen its hatred of the Rohingyas.[76] Its leadership has been heavily implicated in organising the 2012 and 2013 ethnic violence[77] that effectively forced many Rohingya into what are now permanent internal refugee camps. Its leaders[78] have also repeatedly called for the forced expulsion of the Rohingyas[79] and they have increasingly allied themselves with the extremist Buddhist groups.

Buddhist groups

The Buddhist monks are roughly clustered into three groups: the 969 Movement, the MaBaTha and a small group of mostly older clerics who reject the anti-Islamic rhetoric. None of these are political parties in any conventional sense, nor are they particularly tightly organised, but they are influential. The former two seem to be dominant and to see Muslims as threats to Myanmar's Buddhists, leading them to advocate discrimination and sometimes violence against them; their actions often seem calculated to 'driv[e] Islam completely out of the country'.[80] However, the two movements have very different origins despite close similarities in their rhetoric and actions.

The 969 Movement grew out of the 1988 uprising and, at least initially, was opposed to the military regime (many of its older leaders were imprisoned in the 1990s).[81] While it is clear the 969 Movement wields a great deal of influence over the NLD (in particular limiting their willingness to challenge anti-Muslim prejudices and especially to stand up for the Rohingyas),[82] some in the NLD have become worried about where the 969 Movement is trying to take Myanmar.[83]